

Partnership Lead vs. Project Lead: How Data for Good Turns Ideas into Impact

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At Data for Good, many of our projects begin with a simple question:

“We have data — but we’re not sure what to do with it.”

Behind every successful collaboration, there’s a lot of invisible work happening before a single chart is built or a model is trained. One question we’re often asked — especially by nonprofit partners and new volunteers — is:

What’s the difference between a Partnership Lead and a Project Lead?

The titles sound similar, but the roles serve very different purposes. Understanding this distinction helps explain *how* we work, *why* our projects are structured the way they are, and *how* we ensure meaningful outcomes for our partners.



Figure 1.1: Comparison of Partnership Lead vs. Project Lead roles at Data for Good

Why These Two Roles Exist

Data for Good works with nonprofit organizations at very different stages of data readiness. Some partners come to us with a clear problem and a specific question. Others have data, but aren't yet sure what's possible — or what's realistic.

To support both situations, we separate our work into two phases:

- **Before a project exists**
- **After a project is approved**

That's where the Partnership Lead and Project Lead come in.

Two Roles, Two Moments in the Project Lifecycle

1. Project Stage

Partnership Leads work at the *pre-project* stage.

They connect with nonprofit organizations, listen to their challenges, and help shape early project ideas. Their goal isn't to promise a solution — it's to explore what's possible.

Project Leads step in *after* a project is approved.

They guide the execution phase, working with volunteers to deliver the project from start to finish.

In short:

- Partnership Leads help define the *right* project.
- Project Leads help deliver the project *well*.

2. Responsibilities

Partnership Leads focus on:

- Outreach and relationship-building with nonprofits
- Understanding organizational goals and data needs
- Scoping potential projects that align with volunteer skills
- Representing and promoting Data for Good's mission

They spend most of their time asking questions — and listening carefully.

Project Leads focus on:

- Managing project timelines and milestones
- Leading volunteer teams
- Maintaining communication with nonprofit partners
- Delivering insights, documentation, and training

They turn plans into action and ideas into outcomes.

3. Team Interaction

A key difference between the two roles is how they interact with teams.

Partnership Leads don't directly manage volunteers. Instead, they help ensure that nonprofit needs are matched with the *right* skills and expectations *before* a project begins.

Project Leads actively lead and support a volunteer team throughout the entire project lifecycle — from kickoff to final delivery.

Both roles involve collaboration, but in different ways and at different times.

4. Role Identity

We often describe the roles like this:

- **The Partnership Lead is the bridge-builder.**
They connect with nonprofits first — building trust, clarifying needs, and shaping ideas.
- **The Project Lead is the guide across the bridge.**
They lead the team forward, ensuring that the project reaches the other side and creates real impact.

Neither role is “more important” than the other — they simply show up at different moments in the journey.

At Data for Good, we've learned that strong impact doesn't come from doing everything at once. It comes from knowing when to listen, when to plan, and when to lead.

How does the clarity help?

Clear roles help everyone succeed.

For our nonprofit partners, this clarity means fewer unknowns.

It helps answer questions like:

- “*Who should I talk to right now?*”
- “*What happens next?*”
- “*When does an idea turn into a real project?*”

By separating discovery from delivery, we create space for better conversations early on — and smoother collaboration later.

For volunteers, clear roles can also mean:

- Better-scoped projects
- Clear leadership during execution
- A more meaningful experience using their skills for good

For Data for Good, it allows us to grow responsibly — scaling our impact without losing clarity, trust, or quality.

Turning Collaboration into Impact

At Data for Good, our goal isn't just to work with data — it's to work *with people*. Distinguishing between Partnership Leads and Project Leads helps us honor different kinds of leadership: one rooted in listening and alignment, the other in execution and delivery.

Together, these roles help turn curiosity into clarity — and ideas into impact.